



Chaos Gardening

Ecology, permaculture and smart planning
combined into a garden that helps itself grow

A FREE GUIDE

chaostuin.be

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What is a chaos garden?



A chaos garden: dense, mixed, and yet you know exactly what's where.

A chaos garden is a form of ecological gardening where plants grow closely together, without fixed rows, so the garden largely sustains itself. Instead of a tightly laid-out vegetable garden with neat rows, monocultures and a lot of digging, soil, plants and animals are left to find their own balance as much as possible — you step in where needed, rather than controlling everything.

The name sounds contrary, and that's deliberate. A traditional system of order — straight rows, one crop per bed, bare soil in between — doesn't sustain itself; a natural ecosystem, like a forest or a verge, does, for millions of years, without anyone maintaining it. Chaos gardening tries to bring some of that self-regulation back into the vegetable garden.

Chaos gardening combines four ideas:

1

Ecology

The garden as a small ecosystem, not a production line.

2

Permaculture

Design so plants, animals and soil support each other.

3

Combining

No monocultures, but species growing together.

4

Smart planning

Thinking ahead, so you need to adjust less afterwards.

Ecology — the garden is treated as a small ecosystem, not a production line. Insects, soil life and “weeds” are given a role instead of being fought.

Permaculture — design principles aimed at arranging a garden so that plants, animals and soil support each other, with as little outside input as possible.

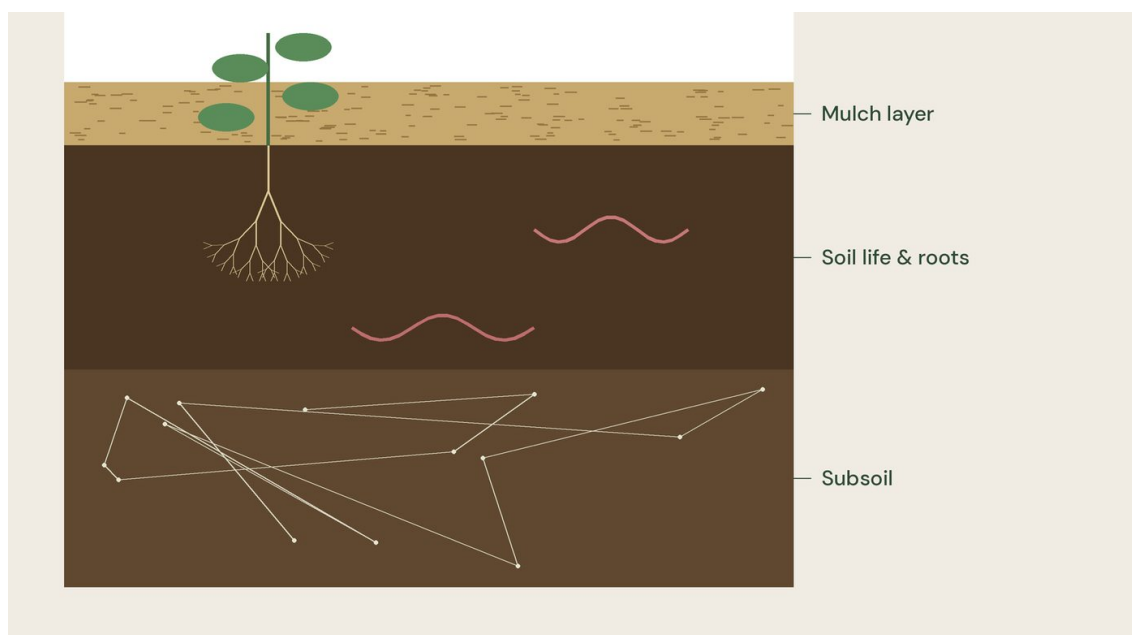
Combining instead of separating — no beds of a single crop, but different species growing together. That gives pests less of a foothold and keeps the soil better covered.

Smart planning — the less you have to correct afterwards, the better. Thought goes in advance into plant combinations, ground cover and layout.

Who is it for. Chaos gardening isn't all-or-nothing. You can adopt parts of it in an existing vegetable garden without overhauling the whole thing at once — and above all it takes patience: in the first seasons a chaos garden can look less “finished” than a classic vegetable garden, while the balance is still settling in.

Soil & no digging

Your soil is not an empty medium — it's a living system that works for you, if you give it the chance.



Under a mulch layer, soil structure stays intact: roots, worms and fungal threads do their work undisturbed.

A healthy soil is full of life and networks: fungal threads, worms and micro-organisms that build structure themselves, hold water and nutrients, and repair themselves as long as you don't disturb them.

How you work with it

- Stop digging or turning the soil.
- Keep the soil covered at all times — with mulch.
- Add organic material on top instead of working it in.
- Don't walk on your growing beds, so the structure doesn't compact.

Nuance. In the beginning it feels slower than a classic approach. But under the surface, the real work starts right away.

Mulch

Cover your soil and let nature do the work — mulch is worth its weight in gold.

Mulch is a layer of plant material that covers your soil: it holds moisture, feeds soil life, suppresses weeds and protects the structure against crusting and drying out.

How you apply it

- Lay a layer of 5 to 10 cm.
- Use what you have: grass, leaves, straw, chipped prunings.
- Top it up continuously, all year round — not just once a season.
- Mulch everywhere, except where you're direct-sowing into open ground; there you remove the layer temporarily.

Benefits and drawbacks

The benefits are numerous: far less work, constant soil nourishment, less drying out and crusting from rain, shelter for beneficial organisms, and aesthetic value. The drawbacks are more limited, but real — mulch can make sowing harder, gives slugs a hiding place, and blackbirds sometimes throw it around. Each drawback has a simple remedy.

Nuance. Don't use mulch that mats together — aim for a loose, ideally mixed layer.

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Diversity, combining & polyculture

A garden doesn't need to be perfectly ordered to work well. Variety makes it stronger.



Pollinators find their way when there's enough to choose from.

You let different plants with different traits work side by side. That gives fewer diseases and pests, a natural spread of nutrients and roots, automatic crop rotation, and more balance and resilience.

How you apply it

- Combine species with different traits.
- Respect the space plants need between them.
- Let plants grow into each other a little.
- Fill empty spots right away.

Polyculture — diversity in its most direct form

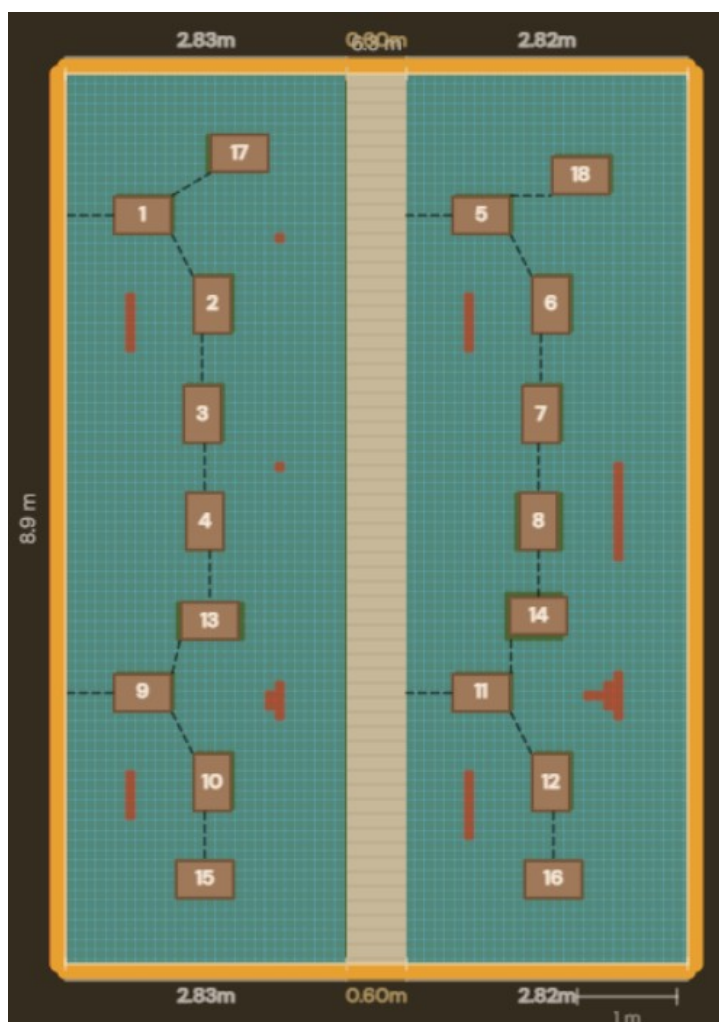
With polyculture you sow a mix of different seeds together on one bed, and let nature decide what germinates and grows the strongest. You harvest gradually as things ripen — the fast growers first, then the slower ones — and the strongest plants fill the freed-up space on their own. Simple to start: one sweep of the hand, a whole bed sown.

Nuance. Polyculture doesn't combine well with a thick mulch layer: before sowing you need to push it aside temporarily, which leaves the seedlings vulnerable to drying out and weeds for a while. A deliberate trade-off, not a free combination. Between tight beds and full chaos, plenty of in-between forms exist.

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Paths & layout

Every vegetable within reach, without ever stepping on the growing soil.



Fixed main paths and stepping stones, generated with the Tuinplanner tool on chaostuin.be.

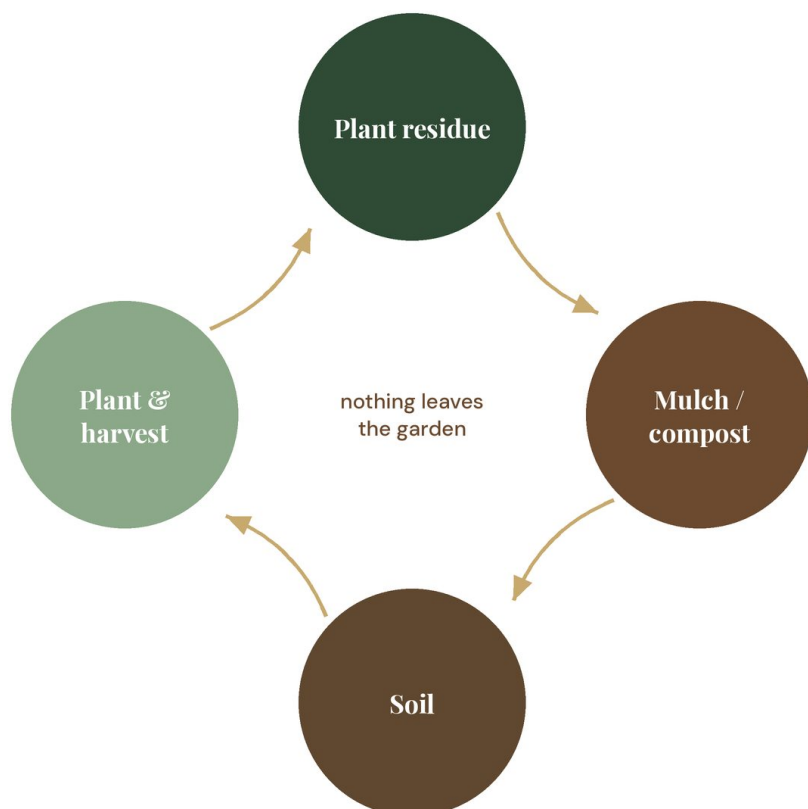
Paths are for wheels, stepping stones for feet. Work with fixed main paths of 60 cm and stepping stones of 40×60 cm between the plants. Everything stays within arm's reach — about 60 cm — so you never need to step on the growing soil. That prevents compaction, which means digging is no longer necessary. And the less path, the more room for vegetables.

The layout of your beds follows the same principle: no rigid plots, but a living puzzle. Build it up layer by layer — plan the large plants or groups first, then fill in smaller species, and combine in both space and time.

Nuance. Chaos doesn't mean everything is random. The structure isn't in straight lines, but in smart combinations. Don't make stepping stones too small either — you're not a tightrope walker.

Cycles & compost

What grows in the garden, stays in the garden. There's no waste, only raw material.



You reuse waste streams in your own garden instead of carting them away. What you remove to eat, you replace with plant material from elsewhere, so the soil doesn't become depleted.

How you apply it

- Leave plant residue in place or use it as mulch.
- Compost what you can't use as mulch.
- Top up with local material — grass, leaves, prunings.
- Remove nothing, except what you eat yourself.

Compost: the black gold of your garden

Compost is broken-down organic material that returns nutrients, stimulates soil life and improves soil structure. You make it by mixing green and brown material, keeping the heap moist but airy, and letting it mature for at least a year — longer is better, turning it two or three times along the way.

Not everything belongs on the compost heap. The right question isn't "can this go", but "can my compost heap safely turn this into food for the soil".

Nuance. Closing the cycle itself takes no time at all. The soil that benefits from it builds up over years — count on about three.

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Sowing, planting & care

A thick mulch layer protects your soil, but makes direct sowing tricky.

Seeds end up too deep in a thick mulch layer, or suffocate. That's why several techniques exist, each suited to a different type of crop:

- Pre-sowing in pots — ideal for lettuce, tomatoes and more.
- Pushing mulch aside temporarily and sowing directly — especially useful for root vegetables that transplant poorly.
- Sowing through the mulch — large seeds like beans, peas, pumpkin or courgette are strong enough to grow through it themselves.
- Buying seedlings from an organic grower — saves time for tomatoes, peppers, aubergines, herbs.
- Sowing between the mulch — filling a furrow or hole with seed compost, ideal for carrots, chard, parsnip.

Don't pick one method for everything, but whatever suits the crop, the season and your mulch layer.

Planting



A young seedling, just planted into a small gap in the mulch.

Push the mulch aside, make a planting hole, water the roots first if the soil is dry, place the plant, and put the mulch back. Adjust the thickness to the size of the plant.

Care

A chaos garden already takes care of a lot by itself: healthier soil, less drying out, more natural predators for pests. But some crops need extra attention during the season — removing side shoots and tying up tomatoes, tying up cucumbers, supporting beans and peas. Others, like lettuce, carrots or onions, need barely any care at all.

Nuance. A chaos garden doesn't need to look perfect. Look after your plants so they stay healthy, not so they look like they came out of a catalogue.

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Pests, weather & adjusting course

In a varied garden, problems often spread far more slowly.



Mulch and dense, mixed planting make a garden more resilient against rain and wind.

Pests are part of gardening. A chaos garden doesn't try to eliminate them, but limits their impact: when plants of the same species all stand together, a problem spreads quickly; when they're spread out among other species, the damage often stays limited. So mix different plant species together and avoid large blocks of the same crop.

You can't control the weather, but you can make your garden more resilient to it. Mulch protects the soil against drying out and heavy rain; varied, dense planting breaks the wind. Extreme weather will never be fully stopped — the goal is limiting damage, not perfection.

Which connects to adjusting course, perhaps the most important skill of all: with a chaos garden, you know where you're starting from, not where you'll end up. A plan is a starting point, not a destination.

How you adjust course

- Sow again if something fails.

- Or try a different plant species.
- Or use whatever came up on its own.
- Let new combinations emerge.

Nuance. Not everything needs to be solved right away. Sometimes it pays to wait and see first.

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Harvesting

The reward for your work — but harvest without disturbing the soil where you can, and your garden keeps improving itself.



What you leave standing keeps feeding the soil — what you harvest, you give back another way.

Not every crop is harvested the same way. Root vegetables you pull up entirely; other crops you cut off just above the soil, so the remaining roots keep feeding soil life and the structure stays intact.

- Harvest root vegetables whole.
- Cut other crops rather than pulling them out.
- Always stay on the paths.
- Use plant residue as mulch or compost.

Nuance. Some plants give multiple harvests. Just let them keep growing.

The Ten Commandments

The ten commandments of the ecological gardener.

1

Above all, love your soil

2

Keep it living and whole

3

Compost feeds every seed

4

And stay off the beds — always heed

5

No feeding chemicals, mind

6

Mulch generously, any kind

7

Flee the digging, flee the plough

8

Plant and sow — enjoy it now

9

Combine with a clever hand

10

And above all: enjoy your land!

DEEPER

Four reflections

The practical guide tells you what to do. These four essays from chaostuin.be's "bedenkingen" series go deeper into why it works.

IF YOU'RE WONDERING...

Why aren't you supposed to dig?

It seems so obvious: you push the spade into the ground, turn the sods over, and you have a fresh, loose soil ready for a new season. Generations of gardeners have done it this way. And yet digging is one of the most damaging things you can do to your soil.

The reason lies beneath the surface — literally. A healthy soil isn't a dead medium. It's a living network of fungi, bacteria, worms and microscopic organisms organised into fine layers. Each layer has its own residents, its own function, its own balance. When you dig, you turn that system completely upside down. The layer that belonged on top ends up at the bottom. Organisms that need light suddenly sit in the dark. Fungal threads that took years to weave are shredded in one motion.

Digging also doesn't solve, in the short term, the problem it claims to solve. Yes, the soil feels looser. But that looseness is temporary. After the first rain the soil compacts again — often more than before digging, because the very structure that kept it open has been destroyed. You create a problem you then have to solve again every year, with the spade.

Nature doesn't dig. In a forest, the soil is never turned over, and yet it's richer, looser and more fertile than any vegetable garden. That's because the soil organises itself: leaves fall, decompose, become humus. Worms dig tunnels that let water through. Roots break up hard layers. The system works — if you let it.

Not digging isn't laziness. It's trust in a system millions of years older than the spade.

IF YOU'RE WONDERING...

Why is diversity so powerful?

A single row of the same plant is the easiest target a pest or disease could ask for. Whatever makes one plant vulnerable makes them all vulnerable — and once an insect or fungus gets a foothold, it finds the next plant immediately, without ever hitting a boundary. Diversity breaks precisely that mechanism. Between any two identical plants stands something different, and that “something different” acts as an obstacle to whatever threatens the one species.

Underground, the same principle plays out, only invisibly. Different plants have different root systems: some deep and penetrating, others shallow and branching. Together they use the soil on multiple levels at once instead of all fishing in the same layer of nutrients and water. Some roots share nutrients with their neighbours through fungal threads; others fix nitrogen from the air and enrich the soil for whatever grows there later.

Above ground, something similar happens with light, wind and microclimate. A tall plant shades one that can't handle full sun. A dense ground cover holds moisture for the plants beside it. A strongly scented plant masks the signal a pest insect uses to find its target. Added up over dozens of species standing together in the same bed, those small advantages form a web that a monoculture simply cannot match.

What all these processes share is that they reinforce each other once enough different players are present. Diversity, then, isn't just “more variety for the look of it” — it's the condition under which all those separate natural processes start strengthening each other, instead of each standing weak and alone.

One plant can do little for itself. A hundred different plants, without you seeing it, are constantly doing something for each other.

IF YOU'RE WONDERING...

What if results take years to show?

A vegetable garden promises something most other pursuits don't: you sow, and within weeks you harvest. That speed is addictive, and it hides an uncomfortable truth at the same time. What you harvest grows fast. What makes that harvest possible — a living, resilient soil — grows slowly. Very slowly. You don't build that in one season, and often not in three.

That contrast creates a real problem, not just a feeling of impatience. You compare your own garden after one year of chaos gardening to a vegetable garden that's been dug and fed every year for ten, and the conclusion seems to be that it "isn't working". But you're comparing two different points on the same trajectory. The soil beneath your feet needs a history to do what you expect of it, and that history only starts counting from the moment you stop disturbing it.

What helps isn't working harder, but measuring differently. Instead of waiting for the end result — a soil that's "finished" — you can see the intermediate steps as proof the system is building itself up: more worms under a spadeful of soil than last year, less compaction after a rain shower, weeds changing species because the soil itself is changing.

And sometimes the most honest attitude is simply this: accept that you're partly gardening for whoever works that soil after you — yourself in five years, or someone else. No forest became rich in one season. Why should a vegetable garden have to?

Your harvest grows in weeks. The soil that makes it possible grows in years. Patience isn't a virtue here, it's simply the timeline the system works on.

IF YOU'RE WONDERING...

Is chaos actually chaos?

Anyone walking between the beds of a chaos garden for the first time often sees exactly what the name promises: no straight rows, plants growing into each other, here and there something that looks like a weed but is apparently allowed to stay. Compared to the straight lines of a classic vegetable garden, it looks like the absence of order. But “no visible order” and “no order” aren’t the same thing.

Every individual reflection in this guide in fact describes a form of order the naked eye doesn’t immediately notice. Weeds that still give a soil signal. Roots spreading across different depths so they don’t compete with each other. Material left lying exactly where it happens to be needed again. None of it is random. It’s order that arose from millions of years of interaction, not order drawn up by a human with a ruler — but order, no less.

The difference, then, isn’t the presence or absence of structure, but who determines the structure. A classic vegetable garden imposes order from above: the gardener decides, the row follows. A chaos garden lets order emerge from below: every plant, every soil organism, every insect follows its own logic, and out of all those separate logics together arises a pattern nobody could have drawn, but that works.

So what “chaos” in chaos garden actually means isn’t the absence of order, but the absence of control over that order. The chaos lies in letting go of the direction, not in the disappearance of structure. What looks at first glance like the least ordered patch of ground on the street is, in reality, the patch where the most organising is happening — just not by you.

Chaos isn’t the absence of order, it’s order nobody imposed from above. The name is a little misleading — it could just as well be called “letting-go garden”.

Curious for more?

This guide is a summary. On chaostuin.be you'll find the full practical guide, with more than twenty in-depth pages and fifteen reflections, plus interactive tools to plan your own garden.

chaostuin.be/en/aanpak — the full practical guide

chaostuin.be/en/bedenkingen — all fifteen essays

chaostuin.be/en/tools — garden planner & mulch calculator